

Masri Writing System

Development Framework — Maktoob be el-Masri

Nezam el-Ketaba el-Masri — مصري Masri

Proposed by — Eqteraah

Diaa Hassouna

Senior Technical Office Engineer · Cairo, Egypt

Mohandis Maktab Fanni Awwal · El-qahera, Masr

اقتراح

ضياء حسونة

مهندس مكتب فني أول · القاهرة، مصر

*Nezam ketaba saoti sona'i el-mostawa le el-lahga el-masreya el-`ameya el-qahereyya,
ya `tamid el-harf el-latini asasan ma`a romouz yonaneya we `ebteya da `ma,
massamam le tah'ee' el-sor`a we el-etesa' we-soholet el-teba`a.*

A two-tier phonetic writing system for Modern Egyptian Arabic (Cairene dialect),
built on a Latin base with optional Greek and Coptic supplementary symbols.

Designed for speed, consistency, and keyboard accessibility.

Masri Writing System Development Framework © 2026 by Diaa Hassouna

Licensed under Creative Commons Attribution 4.0 International — CC BY 4.0

PART ONE — Maktoob be el-Masri (Tier 1: Everyday)

Moqaddema — Introduction

Masri howa neẓam ketaba moqtarah le el-lahga el-masreya el-`ameya, ya`tamid `ala el-harf el-latini asasan, med`oom be-romouz yonaneya we `ebteya le-tamtheel el-aswat elli ma-feesh leeha mo`adelat daqeeqa fi el-abgadeya el-latiniya. El-hadaḡ el-ra'isi men el-neẓam dah howa tadween el-lahga el-masreya el-hadareya el-qahereyya tadweenan saoti daqeeq, be`eedan `an el-arqam elli ba'a keteer men mostakhdemeen li el-internet be yesta`melooha badalan `an el-horouf el-`arabeya.

El-Mabade' el-Asaseya — Core Design Principles

- **Mabda' el-tatabe' el-saoti:** Le-koll soot ramz wahed la gheir, we-le-koll ramz soot wahed la gheir – tafadiyan le-aiy labs aw ghomood.

One symbol per sound – no ambiguity.

- **El-awlaweya lel-basata:** Te'addem el-sor`a we-el-sohola `ala el-anaqa we-el-gamal el-shakli.

Speed and convenience over elegance.

- **El-lahga el-marge`eya:** El-lahga el-masreya el-qahereyya el-hadareya hiya el-me`yar elli byohtakam eleyh.

Urban Cairene Arabic is the normative standard.

- **Nafii el-arqam:** Ma be yesta`melsh ay raqam `arabi aw gharbi badalan `an aiy harf – khilafan lel-`orf el-sha'e` fi el-ketaba el-electroneyya.

No numerals as letter substitutes.

- **'abelyet el-teba`a:** Gamee` romouz el-mostawa el-yawmi 'abla lel-ketaba be-ay lawhet mafateeh latiniya 'eyaseya.

All Everyday-tier symbols typeable on any standard Latin keyboard.

Mostaweyat el-Nezam — The Two-Tier System

El-Mostawa el-Yawmi — Tier 1: Everyday (ASCII)

We howa el-mostawa el-mokhassas lel-esta`maal el-`amm el-yawmi. Ya`tamid hasran `ala el-horouf el-latiniya el-asaseya (ASCII), ma`a esta`maal sona'eyat el-horouf (digraphs) le-tamtheel el-aswat el-morakkaba: **sh** lel-sheen, **kh** lel-kha', **gh** lel-gheyn. Yattsam el-mostawa dah bel-morona fi ketabet el-harakat el-qaseera, ez yagoz hazfaha fi el-seyaqat el-wadha.

TIER 1 EXAMPLE:

Ana baheb Masr — El-ahwa el-masreya ahsan ahwa fi el-donya

El-Mostawa el-Akademi we-el-Thaqaafi — Tier 2: Academic / Cultural

We howa el-mostawa el-mokhassas lel-deraasaat el-loghaweyya we-el-tawtheeq el-`elmi. Yaste`een be-horouf edafeyya mostaqaa men el-abgadeyteen el-yonaneya we-el-'ebteya, le-tamtheel el-aswat el-daqqeeqa elli ya`gaz el-harf el-latini el-mogarrad `an ada'ha:

El-Soot / Sound	El-Ramz el-Akademi	El-Masdar / Source
El-sheen ش	ⲥ	El-'ebteya – Coptic Shai
El-sa (el-faseeh) ث	Ⲑ	El-yonaneya – Theta
El-gheyn غ	Ⲛ	El-yonaneya – Gamma
El-ha' ح	ⲕ	El-abgadeya el-saoteya el-dawleya — IPA
El-`een ع	ⲉ	El-abgadeya el-saoteya el-dawleya — IPA
El-haraka el-taweela ā/ī/ū	ā / ī / ū	El-tar'eem el-saoti

TIER 2 EXAMPLE:

Ana baheb Maṣr — El-ahwa el-maṣreyya aḥsan ahwa fi el-donya

Gedwel el-Horouf el-Kamel — Full Alphabet Table

Harf حرف	El-Soot الصوت	Yawmi Everyday	Akademi Academic	Molahazat — Notes
ء	Soot enfegari hangari – Glottal stop - Hamza	'	ʔ	Yohzaf fi awwel el-kalam – Word-initial silent
ب	b	b	b	—
ت	t	t	t	—
ث	s / t (el-qahereya)	s aw t aw th	θ	Tendimig ma` s aw t fi el-qahera / th fosha
ج	g (Qahereya)	g / j	g / j	Dayemann g fi el-qahera – j fi ba`d el-kalimat
ح	Ha' hal'eya – Pharyngeal h	h	ħ	Ma testa`melsh el-raqam 7
خ	Kha'	kh	x	Sona'i → harf mofracad fi el-akademi
د	d	d	d	—
ذ	z / d (Qahereya)	z aw d	ð	Tendimig fi el-qahera
ر	r	r	r	—
ز	z	z	z	—
س	s	s	s	—
ش	sh	sh	ⲩ	El-Shai el-'ebti – Coptic Shai
ص	s mofakhama – Emphatic s	s	ṣ	El-seya' be yetmayyez fi el-yawmi
ض	d mofakhama – Emphatic d	d	ḍ	El-seya' be yetmayyez fi el-yawmi
ط	t mofakhama – Emphatic t	t	ṭ	El-seya' be yetmayyez fi el-yawmi
ظ	z mofakhama – Emphatic z	z	ẓ	El-seya' be yetmayyez fi el-yawmi

Harf حرف	El-Soot الصوت	Yawmi Everyday	Akademi Academic	Molahazat — Notes
ع	`een hal'eya — Pharyngeal ayin	`aw haraka	ʕ	El-backtick ekhteyari we-mousa beha
غ	gh — Gheen	gh	ɣ	Greek Gamma
ف	f	f	f	—
ق	Soot enfegari (qahereya)	'aw q	q	El-qahera: el-qaaf = soot enfegari zay el-hamza laken fe el-fosha beytketebb qaaf
ك	k	k	k	—
ل	l	l	l	—
م	m	m	m	—
ن	n	n	n	—
ه	h	h	h	—
و	w / oo	w / oo	w / ū	Shoof 'awa`ed el-harakat
ي	y / ee	y / ee	y / ī	Shoof 'awa`ed el-harakat
—	p (kelmat dakheela)	p	p	p ≠ b — Kollohom mosta'elleen. Lel-kalimat el- mo`arraba.

El-saf el-akhdar = emtedad latini, mish harf `arabi aseel. El-Esdaar: tamanya we-`eshreen soot `arabi + harf p (emtedad lel-kalimat el-dakheela) — bedoon aiy raqam wahid.

Nezam el-Harakat — Vowel System

El-Harakat el-'aseera — Short Vowels				El-Harakat el-taweela — Long Vowels			
El-Haraka	El-Soot	Yawmi	Akademi	El-Haraka	El-Soot	Yawmi	Akademi
فتحة	a (short)	a	a		ā (long a)	aa	ā
ضممة	u (short)	o	u	و	ū (long u)	oo	ū
كسرة	i (short)	e aw i	i	ي	ī (long i)	ee	ī
Schwa	ə	(yethezef)	ə				

El-Maqata`an el-Sonaeyyan — Diphthongs

El-Soot	El-Ketaba
اي	ay
او	aw

El-'a`da el-`amma lel-harakat — General Vowel Rule:

El-harakat el-'osayera ekhteyareya fi el-ketaba el-taleea'a, we-elzameya fi mawade` el-eltebas we-fi mawad ta`leem el-logha.

Short vowels are optional in fluent writing but required in ambiguous contexts and in language learning materials.

Mo`alaget el-`Een — The `Ayn Rule (Most Critical)

El-`een fi el-mostawa el-yawmi leeha kheyarayn mota'kafe'en:

El-Kheyar el-Awwal — Option A (El-hazf / Minimal)

El-`een sammeta — bass el-haraka el-moheeta be tetketeb. Deh el-asra`, we el-mashhoura fi el-ketaba el-gheer rasmeyya. *Fastest, most common approach in casual writing.*

El-Kheyar el-Tani — Option B (Backtick — Mousab beh)

El-`een tetketeb be-backtick (`), mawgouda fi el-rokn el-'oddam el-yesar men koll loohet mafateeh, we motamayeza basareeyan `an el-fasla el-`olya el-mosta`mala lel-soot el-enfegari. *Optional but recommended wherever the ayin's pharyngeal quality matters for clarity.*

Harf عربي	Option A — Hazf	Option B — Backtick (Mousab beh)	Akademi	Ma`na — Meaning
عارف	aref	`aref	ʕaref	Knowing
بعدين	badeen	ba`deen	baʕdeen	Afterwards
عشان	ashan	`ashan	ʕaʃʃan	Because / for
على	ala	`ala	ʕala	On / upon
معاك	maak	ma`ak	maʕak	With you

⚠ El-backtick (`) howa el-ramz el-mousa beh lel-`een fi el-ketaba el-yawmeya. Ma testa`melsh el-raqam (3) lel-`een — abadan. *Never use numeral 3 for ع.*

El-'awa`ed el-Emla'eya — Spelling Rules

El-'a`da el-Oola — Rule 1: El-Edgham (El-tad`eef) — Gemination

El-tad`eef yetketeb be takraar el-harf.

حب → **hobb** · جدا → **geddan**

El-'a`da el-Tanya — Rule 2: Adat el-Ta`reef — Definite Article

Tetketeb dayman **el-** be-sarf el-nazar `an el-shamseya we-el-'amareya fi el-nut'.

البيت → **el-beet** · الشارع → **el-share`**

El-'a`da el-Taleta — Rule 3: El-Soot el-Enfegari el-Hangari — Glottal Stop

Ma yetketebsh fi awwel el-kelma. أنا → **ana** (mesh '**ana**'). Amma fi west el-kelma we-akhereha fa be yetketeb fasla `olya '.

بياع → **bayya`**

El-'a`da el-Rabe`a — Rule 4: Salaheyet el-Sona'eyat — Digraph Integrity

sh we **kh** we **gh** wehadat la tenfasil `an ba`d abadan.

مشكلة → **moshkela** ✓ · **mos-hkela** ✗

El-'a`da el-Khamisa — Rule 5: El-qaaf el-qahereya — Cairene ق

Tetketeb fasla `olya ' fi el-yawmi (soot enfegari), aw q fi el-faseeh we-el-asma' el-rasmeyya.

قال → '**aal** (everyday) · قرآن → **Qur'an** (rasmi)

El-'a`da el-Sadsa — Rule 6: Harf el-P — The Letter P

El-p harf mosta'ell tamm fi el-Masri. **P** ≠ **B**. Kollohom mosta'elleen we be yomassalo sawtayn benot'ain mokhtalefeen. El-p be yosta`mel fi el-kalimat el-dakheela we el-mofradat el-hadeesa el-mosta`ara men el-Ingliizi we-el-Faransawi.

Harf el-P — El-Kalimat el-Dakheela we-el-Mofradat el-Hadeesa

El-Masdar / Source	Be-el-p (Sah)	Be-el-b (Ghala)	Molahazat
piano بيانو	piano	biano	Ala moo-seeqeya

El-Masdar / Source	Be-el-p (Sah)	Be-el-b (Ghala)	Molahazat
pizza بيتزا	pizza / pitza	bizza	<i>Akl dakhe el</i>
parking باركنج	parking	barking	<i>Labbs bedoon p</i>
plastic بلاستيك	plastic	blastic	—
printer برنتر	printer	brinter	<i>Mofradat taqneya</i>
project بروجكت	project	broject	<i>El-seya' el-mehani</i>
passport پاسپور	passport / passpour	bassport	<i>Wasa'eq rasmeyya</i>
pump بمبة	pump	bumb	<i>Mostalah handasi</i>

Daleel el-'awa`ed we-el-Osloub — Grammar and Style Guide

El-Mobtada' — Capitalization

Awwel koll gomla be toktab be harf kebeer zay el-Inglizi. El-asma' el-`alam dayman be-harf kebeer: **Masr · Ahmed · Ramadan · el-Azhar**. Adat el-ta`reef el- be horoof soghayara ella law beteftah we be tebda' el-gomla.

El-Tarqeeem — Punctuation

El-tar'eem el-latini el-'eyasi fi koll el-ahwaal: . , ! ? : ; we-`alamet el-e'tebas. La tosta`mel `alamet el-tar'eem el-`arabeya ؟ ؛ ، . El-fasla el-`olya ' btetadda wazeefteen: `alamet el-soot el-enfegari we-`alamet el-hazf – el-se'a' howa el-fasel.

El-Kalemaat el-Dakheela — Loanwords

El-kalemaat el-mo`arraba be tetketab saoteyan zay ma betetnete' fi el-lahga el-masreya:

Harf عربي	Masri Yawmi	El-Masdar
تلفزيون	televezyon	Inglizi – television
كمبيوتر	kombeyoter	Inglizi – computer
موبايل	mobayl	Inglizi – mobile
أوتوبيس	otobes	Faransawi – autobus

El-Khalt ma`a el-Inglizi — Code-Switching

El-kalemaat el-Inglizeya el-madmouga fi el-kalam el-Masri tetketeb be ketabitha el-Inglizeya el-asleeya. Mesh mohtaga t "Massarha":

Ana mesh fahem el-deadline.

El-Tah'ee' el-Emla'i lel-Kalemaat el-Aktar Tadawolan — Standardized Common Word List

Harf `arabi	Yawmi — Everyday	Akademi — Academic	Molahazat — Notes
إن شاء الله	inshala / insha'allah	inṣyāʔallāh	Kelma wehda fi el-yawmi

Harf `arabi	Yawmi — Everyday	Akademi — Academic	Molahazat — Notes
قَهْوَة	ahwa	ʔahwa	El-ahera tetehzaf el-awwel
أَيَّوَة	aywa	aywa	—
مَش	mesh	miyy	—
يَعْنِي	yaani / ya`ni	yaʕni	—
كِدَة / كَدَة	keda	kida	—
عَشَان	ashan / `ashan	ʕaɣʃan	—
بَس	bass	bass	—
زَي	zay	zay	—
وَاللَّهِ	walla / wallahi	wallāh / wallāhi	—
الْحَمْدُ لِلَّهِ	elhamdolilla / hamdilla	elḥamdillāh	Kelma wehda fi el-yawmi
بِسْمِ اللَّهِ	besmela	bismillāh	—
مَا شَاءَ اللَّهُ	mashalla / masha'allah	māɣʃāʔallāh	—
يَا رَبِّ	ya rab	yā rabb	—

El-sabaat el-emla'i – mish kamal el-nezam – howa elli yekfol loh el-enteshaar we el-estemaraar.

Consistency matters more than perfection. The standardized word list is the constitution of the system.

Nossous Tatebi'eya — Sample Texts

TIER 1 — EL-MOSTAWA EL-YAWMI (EVERYDAY)

Ana baheb Masr. El-ahwa el-masreya ahsan ahwa fi el-donya. Keda mesh ra'y, dah ha'ee'a.

TIER 2 — EL-MOSTAWA EL-AKADEMI (ACADEMIC)

Ana baheb Maşr. El-ahwa el-maşreyya ahsan ahwa fi el-donya. Kida miyy ra'y, dah ha'i'a.

HARF EL-P — P-LETTER DEMONSTRATION

El-printer fi el-maktab wa'ef. Mama, el-pizza gayya? Ana ma`aia el-passport. El-pump el-gedeed be`mel shoghl be el-kombeyoter.

CODE-SWITCHING — KHALT MA`A EL-INGLIZI

Ana mesh fahem el-deadline. El-project fe el-server mawgood. Mesh 'aader aftah el-laptop dah.

HARF `ARABI — ORIGINAL ARABIC SCRIPT

أنا بحب مصر. القهوة المصرية أحسن قهوة في الدنيا. كدة مش رأي، ده حقيقة.

Khitma — Conclusion

Yomassel nezam Masri mohawla giddeyya le-taqneen el-ketaba el-`ameya el-Masreya `ala ossos saoteya sareeha we sarema, be`eed `an el-fawda el-emla'eya el-montashera fi el-fada' el-raqmi. We be yastenad fi benyeto `ala toras el-hadara el-Masreya zataha, `ashan be yestarge` el-harf el-'ebti we el-yonani elli taalama kano be yekhdemo el-logha el-Masreya el-'adeema, `ashan yehottohom fi khedmet el-`ameya el-hayya el-naharda.

El-sabaat el-empla'i — mesh kamal el-nezam — howa elli yekfal loh el-enteshaar we el-estemaraar.

الثبات الإيماني - لا كمال النظام - هو ما يكفل له الانتشار والاستمرار

Masri Writing System Development Framework © 2026 by Diaa Hassouna is licensed under Creative Commons Attribution 4.0 International.
To view a copy of this license, visit <https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by/4.0/>

Maktoob be el-Masri — Written in the Masri script proposed in this framework.